FACILITATING MEETINGS

The Facilitation Toolkit

Simple tools for everyday meetings: setting expectations, timeboxing, ROTI, round robin, 1-2-4-All, brainwriting, dot voting, fist to five, and the parking lot.

What this resource is for

A great deal of everyday leadership work happens inside meetings, and the quality of those meetings depends on a small number of learnable choices. The tools in this resource are simple by design. Their value comes from consistent use, not from complexity.

Framing and pacing a meeting

Setting expectations means being explicit, at the start of a meeting, about what kind of meeting this is and what is expected of the people in the room. This includes the meeting's goal, but also practical things: whether this is a working session or a briefing, whether disagreement is welcome or the group is finalising something already decided, how long it will run, and what a good outcome looks like. Most wasted meeting time comes from participants operating on different, unstated assumptions about what kind of conversation they are in. A brief, explicit framing at the start, often no more than two sentences, prevents a surprising amount of friction later.

Timeboxing means assigning a fixed, visible time limit to an agenda item or a discussion, and holding to it even if the topic does not feel finished. A timebox is not a way to rush people. It is a way to force early prioritisation, since a group that knows it has fifteen minutes for a topic behaves differently than a group that believes it has as long as it needs. When a timebox runs out and the topic is not resolved, the honest options are to extend it deliberately and visibly, to park the remainder for a follow-up conversation, or to close it with whatever has been decided so far. What a timebox should never do is quietly disappear, with the meeting simply running long without anyone noticing or naming it.

ROTI (Return on Time Invested) is a one-minute closing practice for any meeting. At the end of the session, each participant rates the meeting on a scale from one to five: 1 is a waste of time, 2 is not worth it, 3 is okay, it could have been better, 4 is a good use of time, and 5 is excellent, the best use of our time. Participants can simply hold up fingers, write a number on a sticky note, or respond in a chat. The facilitator then asks briefly what would have made a 4 a 5, or what made a low score low. ROTI works because it is fast, it is quantifiable over time so patterns become visible, and it gives quieter participants a low-pressure way to signal a problem with the meeting itself, not just its content. Keeping a visible record of ROTI scores across a series of sessions, for example on a flip chart, builds the habit of treating a meeting's usefulness as something to actively check, not something to assume.

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Structuring participation

Round robin means giving each person a turn to speak once, in a fixed order, before opening the floor to general discussion. It stops one or two voices dominating a conversation and gives quieter participants guaranteed airtime without having to compete for it.

1-2-4-All structures a discussion in stages. Participants think alone for a minute, then pair up to compare notes, then join with another pair to form a group of four, before the whole room hears a short summary from each group of four. It surfaces more ideas than moving straight to open discussion, and nobody can stay silent for the whole exercise the way they might in a large group.

Brainwriting asks everyone to write their ideas down silently before anyone speaks. It removes the anchoring effect of whoever happens to speak first, and it gives people who think better in writing than out loud a fair chance to contribute.

Prioritising and checking support

Dot voting gives each participant a fixed number of marks, physical dots or digital votes, to place against a list of options. It turns a long list into a visible order of priority quickly, without debating every item on the list in turn.

Fist to five is a fast way to check the level of support for a decision before finalising it. Each person shows zero to five fingers, from no support at all to full support, and a facilitator can see at a glance whether the group has genuine agreement or whether a few low scores need to be talked through before moving on. It works well as the closing gesture for consent-based decisions.

Protecting focus

The parking lot is a visible place, a flip chart or a shared document, for questions or topics that come up but do not belong in the current conversation. Writing them down rather than either ignoring them or chasing them immediately protects the meeting's focus while still respecting that the point raised mattered enough to capture.

Further reading

- Lipmanowicz, H. and McCandless, K.: The Surprising Power of Liberating Structures. The source of 1-2-4-All and many other simple formats for structuring participation.
- Kaner, S., Lind, L., Toldi, C., Fisk, S., and Berger, D.: Facilitator's Guide to Participatory Decision-Making. A thorough reference for facilitation techniques and group decision-making.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/effective-meetings/facilitation-toolkit